The Oakland Tribune

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East beast

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Sunday

MARCH 16, 1997

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Sunny
High 74 ... Low 49
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CUE

Magic touch

■ Local novelist mixes Bengali folk tales with East Bay setting

Comet's tail, lunar eclipse soon to grace evening sky

By Nancy Mayer
STAFF WRITER

Comet Hale-Bopp, that famous smudge in the morning sky, is getting brighter and recently started making evening appearances.

For people who couldn't wipe sleepy dust from their eyes in time to catch the pre-dawn views, opportunity is knocking on the northwest horizon after 7 p.m. through mid-April.

"It will be a great show," said Jose Olivarez of Chabot Observatory in Oakland. "I tell kids, 'When you're 80 years old, you're going to tell people about it: 'Yeah, I saw Hale-Bopp when I was a kid way back in 1997.' "

■ Be sure to watch the skies. Schedule of events. A-13

Hale-Bopp's brightness will increase over the next two weeks as the ancient traveler from the frosty outer reaches of space gets closer to our sun. Its intensity will peak April 1, and then will diminish gradually.

A double treat awaits sky watchers next Sunday night, when comet viewing will coincide

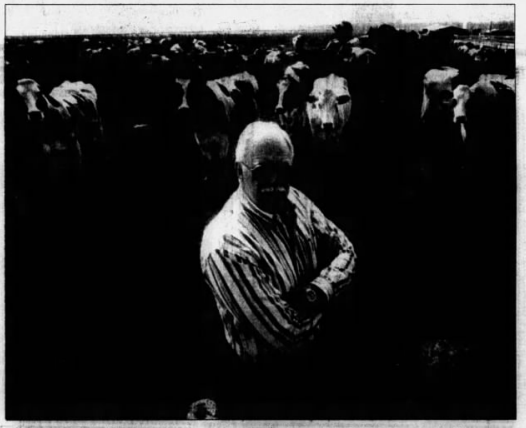
Please see Sky, A-13

Champs!

Charicka Davis (left) and Shavaki Jackson celebrate after the Berkeley High School's girls basketball team defeated Monte Vista of Danville 56-39 to win the NorCal title. Please see sports Page B-1

DINO VOURNAS — Staff

Milk money



Rick Michel, like other dairy farmers, is experiencing hard times due to the price of milk.

The debate rages over the price of milk. Consumer groups think the retail price should reflect the drop in farmers' prices. Grocers say their prices are fair, based on competition and sales.

Rick Michel walks around his 350-acre dairy farm every day at sunrise and marvels at what he sees: a thousand healthy cows, and golden fields of alfalfa and hay.

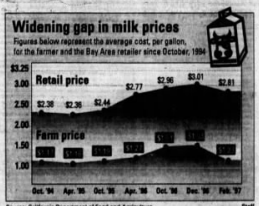
But these days are far more frustrating than glorious for Michel and other ranchers like him because the cream of the crop — the soaring prices that milk commands — eludes them.

On Feb. 1, California's 2,300 dairy farmers suffered an overnight 20 percent drop in raw milk prices — from $1.53 to $1.23 per gallon. Meanwhile, consumers were paying the highest prices in three years to buy their milk off supermarket shelves.

"It's a very, very difficult time. For most of us, it's been a break-even to a loss situation. A lot of us are operating on equity," said Michel, a third-generation dairy farmer. "And if the producer is losing money, he's not going to milk cows for very long."

Although farmers took their 20 percent hit last month, milk prices in Bay Area grocery stores dropped an average of only 17 cents, from $2.98 to $2.81 a gallon, after having climbed to an average of $3.01 in Decem-

Please see Milk, A-12



> "Our research has shown the more unstable the prices have been in the previous 12 months, the higher the retail price will be."
>
> **Bees Butler,** dairy economist, University of California at Davis

story by **CAROLYN JONES** □□□ photo by **NICK LAMMERS**

Marines rescue 731 in Albania

Country falls into anarchy

FROM WIRE REPORTS

TIRANA, Albania — Greek frogmen and U.S. Marines backed by choppers and hidden sharpshooters made speedy forays into Albania on Saturday to evacuate hundreds of foreigners trapped by the country's descent into anarchy.

A total of 431 Americans had been evacuated by late Saturday, completing the rescue of all U.S. citizens who wanted to leave and were able to make their way to the capital city of Tirana, the State Department said.

Early this morning, an Albanian military vessel carrying about 500 Albanians ran aground in rough waters about a mile off the port of Brindisi, Italy, sparking panic among the refugees.

Italian authorities began a rescue, and two coast guard boats ferried the Albanians to shore. Officials said some people had minor injuries. Two people who jumped from the grounded boat and attempted to swim to shore were missing.

The U.S. rescue operation is focused on bringing out non-Americans on a space-available basis. Marines using helicopters Saturday ferried out more than 300 citizens of 32 other countries, State Department officials said.

Greeks stormed ashore at the port of Durres, fired over the heads of an armed mob and evacuated 250 Chinese, Jordanians and Syrians.

The unrest threatens to swamp neighboring countries with refugees. Greece and Italy are most at risk, but there also is concern that the instability will spread eastward to Serbia's Kosovo province and Macedonia, where many ethnic Albanians live.

Please see Rescue, A-12

Amelia's husband not an ideal marital co-pilot

Earhart
many felt she was a gracious woman

By Angela Hill
STAFF WRITER

OAKLAND — Amelia Earhart was as gracious as could be. But her husband was a stinker.

That from Dorothy Manke of Fremont, who describes herself as "not a spring chicken now," but just a little girl in the 1930s when she met the famous flyer.

"It was the biggest thrill of my life. To meet her. To see her take off," Manke said. It'll be 60 years ago to the day on Monday, when Earhart soared out of Oakland on her planned round-the-equator flight. Sixty years ago when a little Do-

Please see Husband, A-13

GOOD MORNING

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Where Bernardos

Tracy Chapman, Metallica each win four awards at the music event in San Francisco. A-3